> refugee problem that the Arab states that invaded Palestine at the end of the Mandate period placed as a precondition to any negotiations for resolving the conflict. At the foundation of the British approach was the colonial consideration that obliged good relations and cooperation with the greater Arab world in the entire Middle East over support for the tiny State of Israel.

Bernadotte's statement on the refugees' "right of return" was discussed by the General Assembly on December 11, 1948, and it was indeed treated as his last will and testament, to be honored. Article 11 of the General Assembly's Resolution 194, which was adopted at the end of this discussion, stated, *"The refugees wishing to return to their homes and live at peace with their neighbors should be permitted to do so at the earliest practicable date."*

Despite the clear support for the general idea of the return of the refugees, the decision qualified it by determining that the return was conditional on the "practicable" circumstances that would allow it. This resolution also established the Conciliation Commission, whose task was to assist in the implementation of the decision.

The United States was chief among the Western powers that supported General Assembly Resolution 194. This decision, from the moment it was passed, has been a headless nail of the Arab-Israeli conflict. As Benny Morris points out, almost everyone believed that its realization would be hindered by two factors—first, Israel's likely refusal to permit a mass return, and second, the expected refusal of at least some of the refugees to live under Israeli rule. In early 1949, for example, the mufti Haj Amin al-Husseini was one of the most outspoken opponents of the return of the refugees to areas under Israeli rule.

All those involved in dealing with the refugee issue, including Bernadotte and Ethridge, understood by the end of 1948 that the real solution to the refugee problem was their resettlement in areas held by the Arabs and in the Arab states, in particular Syria and Iraq. However, they believed that it was only just that Israel contribute to resolving the problem by absorbing 250,000 to 300,000 refugees in the State of Israel.

The reality was, though, that the demographic balance of the State of Israel at the time was such that the absorption of this number of refugees was tantamount to national suicide. At the time of the signing of the